Kevin Mitnick, an American hacker, characterised in a book written by his capturer, Tsutomu Shimura, as ‘America’s Most Wanted Outlaw’. ‘This makes me ill,’ I wrote. ‘Tsutomu, when Mitnick croaks, will you dig up his grave and rent his hands out as ashtrays? The man who murdered one of the last notorious American gunslingers went on not long after to produce and act in a strange show which described just How He Did It. Some years later, he himself was murdered by a disgusted member of the audience.’

People were feasting on us and on our naivety, but the fact was that, by the time of the trial, the old hacking scene was dead. The Internet had made it too easy and many of the new breed were too brazen about what they did. It had become part of the pop and film culture, and some of us were already thinking about other ways in which secrets could be accessed or revealed.

The other two wanted to plead guilty but I didn’t want to collaborate, so to speak, in my own criminalisation. By the trial date, I faced thirty-one charges; Prime Suspect, twenty-six; and Trax, six. Part of our crime was to have written articles for our own International Subversives magazine, which had a circulation of three – the three of us. Stress breeds stress, of course. And by the time of the committal hearing in Melbourne Magistrates’ Court my mind was blown apart, not least by the news that Prime Suspect had turned Crown Witness against me. As I’ve found again and again to my cost, you don’t get far in this world by over-relying on loyalty. People are loyal until it seems more opportune not to be. I’m sorry if that’s cynical, but experience brings its own slow wisdom. Prime Suspect signed the papers, though he didn’t colour the picture as menacingly as he could have done. When I saw him across the courtroom I stared at him. He looked impassive. He was frightened, he was young, but it was a look that I would come to know: the look of betrayal, organised on the face to look like a high-minded interest in the truth. Nevertheless, it brings a focus to your life, the moment when a judge says, ‘The prisoner shall now rise’, and the only person standing is you. I once said true belief begins at that point. In my line of work, true belief begins with that and with the jackboot at the door.

Prime Suspect, having pleaded guilty, was heard some time before me. There was no custodial sentence, a $5,000 good behaviour bond, and an order to pay reparations to the Australian National University to the tune of $2,100. The judge made the point that no special leniency had been afforded Prime Suspect as thanks for his co-operation. That was a sad